

beating his head against a brick wall. How many different ways could he tell them, “It’s not mine”?

It’s Not Mine!

He was on the phone for the tenth time, or the hundredth, with customer service – tired, frustrated, exasperated:

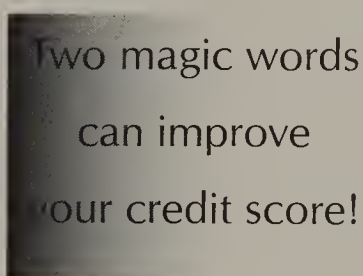
Kurt: I have done everything I could to correct this error. I have never had an American Express card, ever, in my life. I do not owe \$15,000 to American Express. I do not owe \$15,000 to anyone. This debt is not mine! I don’t know what else to do. I must be the victim of “*identity theft*.”

Customer Service: Oh my goodness, let me transfer you.

Manager: Hello, sir, we are so sorry for your inconvenience. I will delete that from your record right now. I will issue you a new platinum card today, and for your trouble, I will express mail it, so you should get it immediately.

It’s Not Yours!

The two magic words here are “*identity theft*.” A few years ago, it was a rarity, but now it is a daily occurrence, and the people doing it are getting better and better every day. The FTC estimates that each year, nearly **ten million** American consumers have their identities stolen.



This means that today, as you read this, about 27,400 people will have their identity stolen in some way! The commission also states that 15,000 to 20,000 of these consumers contact them each week. Ten million people each year! That’s in one year; in five years, we are talking about fifty million people!

A 2006 survey estimated total losses to victims from ID theft at \$15.6 billion! Losses to businesses from ID theft amount to \$50 billion every year, for totally unnecessary costs. And those costs are passed on to all of us.